

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Biotechnology English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For biotech scientists, translational researchers, assay-development teams, platform teams, program managers, alliance managers, business-development staff, and biotech executives.

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Assay Development and Reproducibility

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

03 Biomarkers and Translational Strategy

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Preclinical Data Packages

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 CMC and Scale-Up in Biotech

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

06 IP, Freedom to Operate, and Collaboration

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Investor and Board Updates

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Partnering and Business Development

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A platform produces a promising signal in one experimental system. An investor slide says it will work across several diseases.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: platform, modality, proof of concept, translatability.

Model response

The finding is promising in this experimental system. We have not established its relevance across diseases. I'll distinguish the current evidence from the broader platform hypothesis.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. One experimental system, not several diseases - Fictional platform review: a signal was observed in one experimental system, while an investor slide claims broad disease applicability.
2. A delivery result is not a therapeutic outcome - Separate fictional research discussion: a platform delivered a reporter into a laboratory cell model; no therapeutic payload or patient outcome was tested.

3. An observed effect with an uncertain mechanism - Separate fictional platform meeting: an experimental effect is repeatable within the supplied study, but the proposed mechanism has not been isolated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A platform claim based on one successful payload

A fictional platform delivered payload A in one test system. Payloads B and C have not been tested. Discuss a partner-facing explanation of what is demonstrated and what remains a platform hypothesis.

Role A: Platform scientist: describe the tested payload and limit the proof-of-concept claim.

Role B: Business development manager: ask how to explain the broader opportunity without claiming universal delivery.

Possible opening: We demonstrated delivery of payload A in this system; the other payloads remain untested.

Success checks

- State the tested scope accurately.
- Separate the platform thesis from evidence of broad applicability.
- Agree a qualified statement and the next unanswered experimental question.

Add a complication: A partner asks you to call the platform payload-independent today.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Assay Development and Reproducibility

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

An assay gives consistent results within one run but different results across three days. A colleague calls it fully reproducible.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: assay, sensitivity, specificity, reproducibility.

Model response

Within-run consistency and performance across days are different questions. Let's report both and investigate the between-day variation before describing the assay as reproducible under those conditions.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. B - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Within-run consistency versus between-day reproducibility - Fictional assay review: results are consistent within one run but differ across three days; no cause has been established.
2. A sensitivity comparison at different thresholds - Separate fictional assay discussion: method A and method B were evaluated using different positivity thresholds and different sample panels.

3. Faster preparation with a sample-volume tradeoff - Separate fictional assay selection: method C uses half the preparation time but twice the sample volume of method D; comparable analytical performance is not yet established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A method tested by only one operator

A fictional assay has consistent results from one operator. A second method has data from three operators, but the two studies used different samples. Compare the evidence needed before claiming the first method is equally reproducible.

Role A: Assay lead: explain the scope of the single-operator evidence.

Role B: Laboratory reviewer: request a comparison using aligned samples and operator conditions.

Possible opening: Our result supports consistency for one operator, not yet the broader operator comparison.

Success checks

- Keep within-operator and across-operator evidence distinct.
- Identify the different sample sets as a comparison limitation.
- Agree common criteria without inventing results for untested conditions.

Add a complication: The team wants to treat the untested operators as equivalent without checking.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Biomarkers and Translational Strategy

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A team calls a biomarker "validated" without specifying whether it means analytical performance or clinical usefulness.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: biomarker, patient stratification, surrogate endpoint, validation.

Model response

What kind of validation do you mean here? Could we distinguish the assay's analytical performance from evidence about the biomarker's clinical use? The slide needs to state which claim the data support.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. What does validated mean here? - Fictional biomarker meeting: a slide calls a biomarker validated without identifying analytical performance or clinical usefulness.
2. Stratification or eligibility? - Separate fictional trial-design rehearsal: a biomarker is labeled for patient stratification, but a recruitment draft says people without it cannot enroll.

3. A biomarker change is not automatically a surrogate endpoint - Separate fictional translational review: an exploratory biomarker changed after exposure; no relationship to clinical outcomes has been established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A cutoff borrowed from another study

A fictional project proposes using a biomarker cutoff from a different study. The populations and measurement methods have not been compared. Hold a clarification conversation about what the cutoff is intended to do in the new project.

Role A: Translational scientist: ask whether the cutoff is exploratory, stratification-related, or proposed for eligibility.

Role B: Clinical project lead: identify the unresolved comparison and request the appropriate review.

Possible opening: Before we borrow this cutoff, could you clarify its intended use in our study?

Success checks

- Clarify the proposed use before discussing adoption.
- Identify population and method comparability as unknown.
- Avoid claiming validation transfers automatically between studies.

Add a complication: A colleague says published means validated for every new population.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Preclinical Data Packages

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An animal study shows an effect at one tested exposure. A summary describes the result as proof of human benefit.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: in vitro, in vivo, toxicity, safety margin.

Model response

The result describes the tested animal model and exposure. It does not establish human benefit. I'll state the finding and the limits on translating it to a clinical setting.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An animal result with a human-benefit overclaim - Fictional preclinical review: an animal study found an effect at one exposure; the summary calls it proof of human benefit.
2. No observed toxicity in a limited experiment - Separate fictional preclinical exercise: no toxicity finding was observed in one short study; longer exposure and other study conditions have not been assessed.

3. Two model results should not be blended into one claim - Separate fictional data-package discussion: an in vitro study shows an effect, while an in vivo study result is inconclusive; reasons for the difference are unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A safety-margin figure without its comparison

A fictional preclinical slide lists a safety margin of five but omits the exposure measure and comparison basis. No underlying values are supplied. Discuss how to qualify the slide before it is presented.

Role A: Toxicology reviewer: ask for the missing basis of the calculation.

Role B: Program presenter: explain that the number cannot yet support a broader safety statement.

Possible opening: The figure five needs its exposure measure and comparison basis before we can interpret it.

Success checks

- Request the missing calculation context.
- Avoid converting the ratio into an unsupported patient-safety claim.
- Agree to verify the source or leave the interpretation unresolved.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks you to translate the number into five times safer for patients.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

CMC and Scale-Up in Biotech

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A process transfer achieved the expected yield in two small runs. Performance at a larger scale remains untested.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: CMC, yield, comparability, tech transfer.

Model response

The two small runs met the expected yield. Larger-scale performance is still untested. I'll present scale-up as an open question and identify the next planned evidence point.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Two small runs do not complete scale-up - Fictional technology-transfer update: two small runs met the expected yield, while larger-scale performance is untested.
2. A transferred procedure without a receiving-site run - Separate fictional tech-transfer meeting: the receiving team has the process documents and completed training, but has not executed a run.

3. A yield result with quality review still pending - Separate fictional CMC exercise: a pilot run met its yield target, but the associated quality-attribute review remains open.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A scale-up run postponed before execution

A fictional larger-scale run was scheduled for Monday but was not executed because equipment readiness was unconfirmed. Two earlier small runs remain the only yield evidence. Give a spoken status update and agree the next planning checkpoint.

Role A: CMC project lead: distinguish the missed activity from an unsuccessful experimental result.

Role B: Portfolio manager: ask which readiness confirmation is needed before a new schedule is proposed.

Possible opening: The larger run did not occur, so we have no new scale-up performance result to report.

Success checks

- Distinguish not executed from failed performance.
- Preserve the two small runs as the existing evidence boundary.
- Agree a readiness check without inventing a new execution date.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to label the postponed run a yield failure.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

IP, Freedom to Operate, and Collaboration

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

Two partners want to exchange materials. The draft arrangement leaves publication and permitted-use questions unresolved.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: IP, freedom to operate, material transfer agreement, publication rights.

Model response

Could the responsible teams confirm the permitted uses and publication terms before the exchange? I'll summarize the scientific purpose and the unresolved questions for review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Clarify permitted use before sending materials - Fictional collaboration discussion: material exchange for assay testing is proposed, but permitted use and publication rights remain unresolved; an internal planning call is Friday.

2. Publication review versus publication permission - Separate fictional academic-industry negotiation: one draft clause says publication review, another says prior permission; the intended arrangement is not agreed.

3. A patent search is not a freedom-to-operate opinion - Separate fictional collaboration preparation: a quick patent-title search found no match for a proposed assay collaboration. No specialist freedom-to-operate review has occurred; the partner planning call is Thursday.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A collaborator requests a new use

A fictional material transfer agreement is under review for assay testing. The collaborator now asks to use the material in a separate screening project. That additional use has not been reviewed. Hold a call requesting a precise scope assessment.

Role A: Alliance scientist: identify the additional proposed use and request review before commitment.

Role B: Technology transfer manager: ask for the new project's purpose and route the scope question to authorized reviewers.

Possible opening: The screening project is a new proposed use, so we need it reviewed rather than assume assay testing covers it.

Success checks

- Separate possession of material from confirmed permitted use.
- Make a specific request for scope review.
- Avoid giving a legal conclusion or promising approval.

Add a complication: The collaborator says the material is already on-site and therefore any use is allowed.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Investor and Board Updates

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A project update lists completed experiments but does not connect them to the next funding milestone.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: milestone, runway, inflection point, risk mitigation.

Model response

I'll group the results around the milestone question: what have we learned, what remains uncertain, and what evidence is needed next? That will make the funding discussion easier to follow.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Completed experiments versus the funding milestone - Fictional board preparation: three assay runs at site A met the within-site criterion. The next funding-review milestone requires reviewed evidence from both sites A and B; site B has not run the assay, and funding is not guaranteed.

2. A milestone reached with a remaining uncertainty - Separate fictional board exercise: a predefined assay milestone is achieved, but between-site performance remains untested and was outside that milestone's scope.

3. Runway under two spending assumptions - Separate fictional finance rehearsal: current cash supports nine months at one planned spending rate and six months at a higher proposed rate; neither plan is selected.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A milestone date moved without new results

A fictional program moves its target milestone from June to August because a study is rescheduled. No new result exists. Explain the difference between a planning change and a scientific setback in a board conversation.

Role A: Program leader: report the changed date and unchanged evidence status.

Role B: Board representative: ask about dependencies and runway implications without assuming them.

Possible opening: The milestone date moved because the study was rescheduled; we have no new scientific result to interpret.

Success checks

- Separate schedule change from experimental outcome.
- Identify financial and milestone implications as questions requiring assessment.
- Agree the next verified planning update without predicting a result.

Add a complication: A stakeholder wants the update to call the delay proof the technology does not work.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Partnering and Business Development

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A potential partner requests exclusive rights before the scope of the collaboration is defined.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: term sheet, option, exclusivity, due diligence.

Model response

We can discuss exclusivity alongside the proposed scope, responsibilities, and milestones. Could we first clarify which activities and rights you have in mind so the appropriate teams can evaluate the request?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. C - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. B - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. Define the collaboration before discussing exclusivity - Fictional partnering call: a prospective partner requests exclusive rights before the collaboration's scope is defined.
2. A narrow diligence window instead of broad silence - Separate fictional negotiation: a partner wants a six-month halt to all partnering discussions; the proposed project concerns one research field only.

3. Data-room access with a staged scope - Separate fictional partnering case: a potential partner requests the entire data room before agreeing the intended diligence questions; sharing scope is unapproved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A proposed option with no decision trigger

A fictional draft term sheet mentions an option after a research milestone, but does not define the milestone or who confirms it. Hold a negotiation to identify those missing conditions before discussing commitment.

Role A: Business development manager: request a defined milestone and confirmation process.

Role B: Partnering director: explain the need for a usable decision trigger while acknowledging that terms remain proposed.

Possible opening: We can discuss the option structure, but the milestone and confirmation process need to be defined first.

Success checks

- Distinguish a proposed option from an agreed right.
- Clarify the trigger and decision authority without inventing terms.
- Agree the next review step and keep commitment conditional.

Add a complication: The partner asks you to announce the option as secured before those details are reviewed.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.